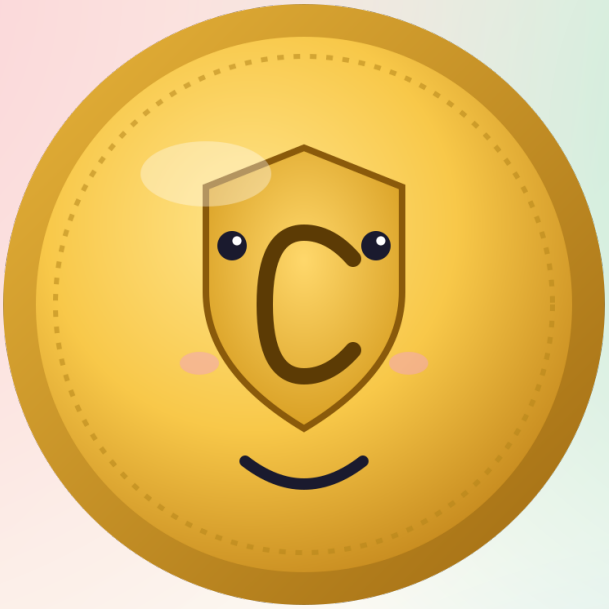
CASH TO COMPANY

K-12 CURRICULUM



GRADE K

Teacher Guide

C A S H

Businesses help people.

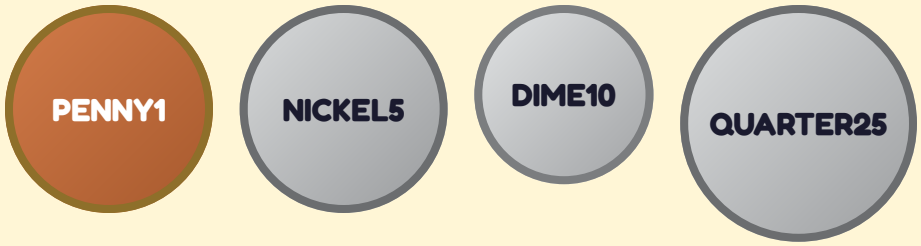
Routines, pacing, and the small moves that work.

Grade K — Cash to Company: Teacher Guide

For: kindergarten classroom teachers, homeschool parents teaching the curriculum, after-school program leads, paraprofessionals supporting K classrooms. **Companion to:** Grade K Curriculum Book, Lesson Plans, Student Activity Book, Cash Video Scripts, and Parent Guide.

How this year is built (and why)

Grade K of Cash to Company is built around a single move: **noticing helpers.** That is the year. Every lesson, every Cash video, every dramatic-play session points at the same thing — a helper is doing a job, that helper is a kind of business, and that business helps people.



We do not teach money this year. We teach coins. There is a difference. Money is an abstraction; a five-year-old cannot meaningfully hold "money" in their head. Coins they can hold in their hand. We name four coins, sort four coins, and decide which is more. That is the whole financial spine.

The pedagogical bones come from three traditions that fit early childhood:

- **Play-based learning.** Most of the work of K is dramatic play. Cash's Cafe is the year's centerpiece because children learn the social and operational moves of business through pretend before they could ever learn them through worksheets.
- **Routines, not heroics.** A predictable rhythm — Monday "who helped you today?", a Tuesday/Thursday Word Wall touch, Cash's Cafe twice a week in Unit 4 — is more powerful than any single brilliant lesson.
- **Picture-first.** Every page in the program's K materials is at least 60% illustration. We assume children cannot read fluently. Most can't. The pictures are the lesson.

Classroom routines (the year, on autopilot)

Set these in the first three weeks. Protect them.

The "Who helped you today?" opener (every Cash to Company block)

At the start of every block, ask the question. Take 3–5 answers. Add to the chart paper. By Week 6, children will start saying the answer before you ask.

The Word Wall touch (Tuesdays and Thursdays, 3 minutes)

Point at one word on the wall. Say it. Children echo. Point at one more. Say it. Children echo. Done. Three minutes.

The Helpers Wall add (one per week)

Pick one child each week to add a new helper square. Rotate so every child gets a turn over the year.

The Coin Moment (every block during Unit 2)

Hold up a coin card. "Show me a [coin]." Children point at the coin chart on the wall. Three coins, then done. Three minutes.

Cash's Cafe (twice a week during Unit 4)

Three groups of three children rotate through. Two cycles per session, 15 minutes total. The rest of the class watches and cheers softly.

CASH SAYS

Which coin is more? Show me with your hands.

Pedagogy at this grade band

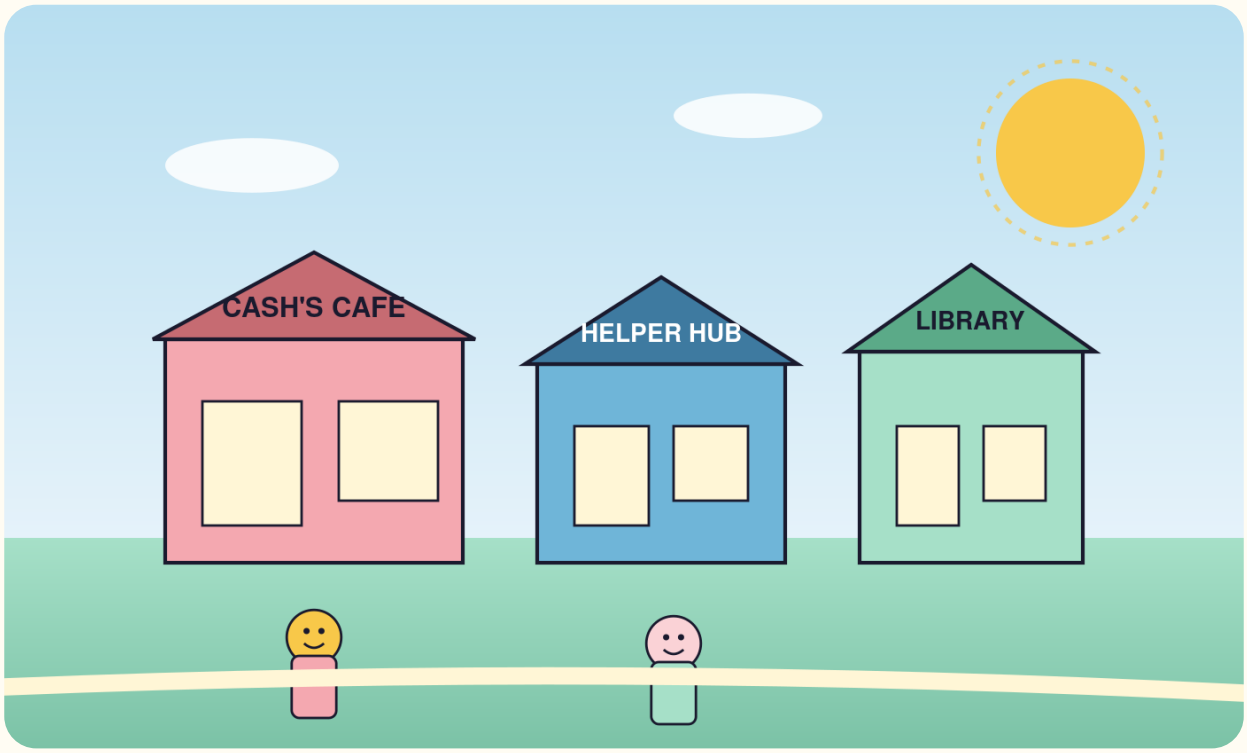
- **Concrete only.** A real coin in a hand beats a "money" word on a page. Real photos of helpers beat abstract drawings. Real bread on a plate beats the idea of a sandwich.
- **Repetition is friendly.** Kindergartners thrive on repeated phrases. "Helpers help. Notice, notice, notice." The teacher says it. The children echo. By Week 12, children say it on their own.
- **Talk, then draw, then sometimes write.** Most kindergartners cannot write fluently. Talking is the assessment. Drawing is the artifact. Writing is teacher-supported (the teacher captures the child's words in adult handwriting on the bottom of the page).
- **Identity-aware.** Many of the helpers children will name are family members. Receive every answer warmly. Avoid corrections that make a child

feel their answer was wrong; redirect by adding a question — "who else helped you outside our home?"

- **Movement-based.** Most lessons include children moving — to the rug, to the wall, to the cafe corner. Wiggly is the default at K. Plan for it.
- **Not a worksheet curriculum.** The Activity Book is mostly drawing and circling. If a teacher finds themselves printing extra worksheets, something has shifted away from the spine. The dramatic play and the noticing routine are the lesson.

Assessment philosophy

Assessment in Grade K is **observation-based**, not written. The class checklist (one page) is the year's gradebook.



Helpers are everywhere. Each one is a kind of business.

We watch for two things:

1. **Did the child do the move the standard names?** Did they actually name a helper? Did they actually point at the dime?
2. **Can they tell a grown-up what they did?** Oral report is the K version of "explanation." A child who can say "first, bread. Next, peanut butter. Last, sandwich." has the standard.

We do not grade neatness. We do not grade spelling (most children cannot spell yet). We do not assign letter grades or numbers. The checklist is Y / N. By June, most children should have most boxes checked. If a box is empty for many children, we re-teach.

A typical assessment cadence

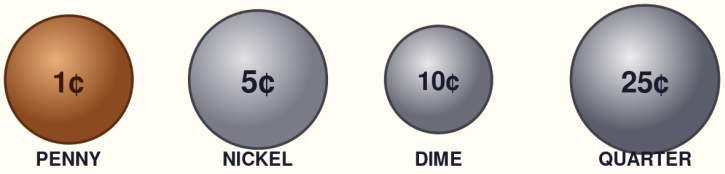
Cadence	Form	Stakes
Daily	Visible-thinking note (the helper a child mentioned, the kind word a child used)	None — formative observation
Weekly	Helpers Wall contribution; Cash's Cafe role-play	None — observation only
End of unit	Class checklist update	Low — for teacher's planning
End of year	Family Visit Day (the showcase)	The year's culmination — observation only

Working with non-readers

- **Read every word out loud.** The Activity Book is designed to be read by the teacher (or family adult) to the child. Do not assume the child can read the prompts.
- **Picture cards beat text cards.** When sorting, matching, or sequencing, use cards with pictures, not words. (Words can sit alongside the picture as exposure.)
- **Sentence frames are spoken, not written.** "This is the helper I noticed." Children rehearse out loud, not on paper.
- **Captions written by the teacher.** When a child draws a helper, ask, "who is this?" Write the child's words in adult handwriting at the bottom. Read the caption back to the child.
- **The Word Wall is a touch-and-say wall, not a read wall.** Children point and say. Reading the words alone comes later (Grade 1).

CASH SAYS

What comes first? What comes next?



Penny. Nickel. Dime. Quarter. We say each name out loud.

Dramatic play setup (the most important environment in the room)

Cash's Cafe is the centerpiece of Unit 4 and runs for nine weeks. Set it up well.

The corner. Pick a corner of the classroom. Small table. Two chairs. A shelf or counter for the menu items.

Aprons. 4–6 paper aprons (or fabric, if available). Children put one on when they take the shopkeeper role.

Pretend food. Felt or paper. Pretzels, apples, cookies, milk cartons. Avoid food labeled as "junk" or "healthy" — just food. Allergies: do not use real food.

Pretend coins. Use coin cards from Unit 2. Children "pay" with cards, not real coins. Real coins appear only in supervised lessons.

The OPEN/CLOSED sign. Children flip the sign at the start and end of each cafe session. This is its own ritual; respect it.

The JOBS chart. Three roles on a small chart inside the cafe corner: shopkeeper, customer, napkin helper. A clip moves to mark whose turn it is. Coach against any child "owning" a role.

Sound and tidiness. The cafe gets loud and silly. That is the work, within reason. The expectation: kind words at all times, hands kept to oneself, the corner stays roughly tidy. The napkin helper handles tidiness — name them as the most important role and the children will believe you.

Classroom management for 5-year-olds (specific to this curriculum)

- **A child won't take a turn at Cash's Cafe.** Don't push. Watching is participation for the first 1–2 sessions. By session 3 or 4, most join. If a child never joins, partner them with a peer; the peer plays, the child holds the OPEN sign. Mark Y on the checklist.
- **A child uses unkind words.** Pause the play. Say the rule: "At Cash's Cafe, we use kind words." Have the child try again. Almost all kindergartners self-correct on the second try. If unkind words continue, redirect to a different role (the napkin helper has fewer speaking lines).
- **Two children fight over the same role.** Use the JOBS chart. Move the clip. "Right now it is Maya's turn to be the shopkeeper. Next, it is Liam's." Repeat. The chart wins more arguments than the teacher.
- **A child finishes early.** Send them to the Word Wall to point at three words and say them. Or to the Helpers Wall to choose their favorite square. Both count as on-task.
- **A child names a "helper" that isn't really one.** Receive warmly. "Yes, my dog Buddy helps me feel happy. That's a kind of helper. Today, let's find a helper outside our house." Redirect. Don't correct.
- **A whole-class meltdown on a hard day.** Skip the lesson. Read a picture book from the anchor list. Children will absorb half the standards from the read-aloud anyway.

Pacing — what to do if you're behind

If you reach Week 18 and Unit 2 isn't done, that's normal. Compress: spend Week 19 finishing coins, then start Unit 3 Week 20. The year is more forgiving at

K than at any other grade. The Capstone (Cash's Cafe) is the protected territory — do not cut Unit 4 below 7 weeks.

CASH SAYS

Tell me what they said with their words.

Common pitfalls

- **Trying to teach money instead of coins.** Resist the temptation to bring in dollars, pricing, or change-making. Save those for Grade 1 (counting to 50¢) and Grade 2 (making change). At K, four coin names is enough.
- **Reading worksheets aloud as if children can follow.** They can't, mostly. Slow down. Point at the picture. Read the prompt. Read it again.
- **Letting the dramatic play drift.** Without the JOBS chart and the kind-words rule, Cash's Cafe will drift into chaos by Week 32. Reset the rules at the start of every session.
- **Skipping the Cash videos.** The videos are 1:30–2:00. They do real work. They are short on purpose. Watch them.
- **Treating it like an academic period.** This is play and noticing. If it feels like a lecture, something has gone wrong.
- **Asking children about family income.** Don't. Ever. Not even a soft version of the question. Family money is off-limits at every grade.

Frequently asked questions

My class includes a wide range of readers — some can read, some can't. How do I run the Activity Book? Read every page aloud, every time. Strong readers won't be insulted. Struggling readers won't be left out.

Can I add my own helpers to the Helpers Wall list? Yes. Use any helpers your community actually has — a fishmonger, a barber, a bus driver, a farm worker, a pediatric nurse. The list in the Curriculum Book is a starting list, not a closing list.

A family asked if their child can interview them about their job for the helper unit. Can we? Sure. Send the child home with a picture card to draw. The grown-up tells the child what they do; the child draws it. Add to the Helpers Wall.

A child has a fine-motor delay and struggles with drawing. Provide pre-printed sticker pages. The child peels and places. The artifact is still the child's choice; the drawing skill is not the standard.

The school doesn't have real coins. Is that okay? Yes. Use coin cards for the whole year. Real coins are nice but not required. Many schools avoid them for handling reasons.

One child can already count by 5s and is bored during the coin lesson. Push them. Add the question: "how much altogether?" Three nickels = 15. Two dimes and a nickel = 25. Mark them as advanced on the checklist. Continue them through the regular lessons; the social lesson (taking turns) is for them too.

Cross-grade hook (what this year sets up for Grade 1)

Grade 1's theme is "Businesses make things or do things." In Grade K, students notice that businesses help. In Grade 1, they sort businesses into "makes a thing" or "does a thing" and explain their sort.

The bridge is sturdy. A child who has spent a year saying "the librarian helps," "the pizza shop helps," "the firefighter helps" is exactly ready to ask "does the librarian make a thing or do a thing?" — answer: does. "Does the pizza shop make a thing or do a thing?" — answer: makes (and does — Grade 1's good first puzzle).

Coin work in Grade K (penny, nickel, dime, quarter, "which is more?") sets up Grade 1's coin counting (mixed coins up to 50¢). Sequencing in Grade K (3 pictures in order) sets up Grade 1's 4-step recipe card. Cash's Cafe in Grade K sets up Grade 1's "classroom store" with worker-customer pairs.

A strong Grade K makes Grade 1 dramatically easier. Plant the routines. Trust the spine.

CASH SAYS

Notice, notice, notice. What did you see?

A note to first-time teachers of this curriculum

You do not need to know anything about business to teach this. You need to be willing to point and say "there's a helper" fifty times until the children point first. Cash will do the heavy lifting on the videos. The lesson plans take the pacing decisions off your plate. Your highest-leverage move is the noticing routine. By Week 12, your room will be a noticing room.

Senior expert upgrade pack — Differentiation deep moves and "if students freeze" plays

Advanced learners — three named extensions for K

The original differentiation notes default to "push for one MORE answer" — true but generic. Here are three concrete extensions a K teacher can run in the same time block:

1. **Two-helper sentence.** Instead of naming one helper, the advanced child names two and tells which one they think is harder work and why. "The bus driver and the cook. The cook is harder because there are lots of kids." This is the seed of value-chain reasoning that lands at Grade 6.
2. **Helper-the-class-doesn't-have.** "Tell me a helper our school does NOT have. What would they do if we did?" This is the seed of business-as-noticing-need that anchors all of Grade 2 and Grade 3.
3. **Coin-pair guess.** Show two coins face down. Child guesses which is more before you flip. Builds memory of value, not just sort.

ELL deep moves

- **Cognate seeds.** Coin words have cognates in many languages: Spanish moneda, French pièce, Vietnamese xu. Use the home-language word once, then the English word three times.
- **Picture-first protocol.** Every K Cash to Company lesson can run picture-only the first time, English-word the second time, child-says-it the third time. Three exposures.
- **Allow the home-language helper.** "What's the helper word in the language you speak at home?" Affirm. Then say the English word.

IEP/504 deep moves

- **Sensory-aware coin sort.** Some children have texture aversion to real coins. Use laminated cards for first exposure. Add real coins for those who reach for them.
- **Voice-volume for shy children.** A child who won't speak the kind words at full voice can whisper to the teacher, who says the line at full voice. This counts.
- **Pre-pair partners.** Don't ask K children to pick partners cold. Pre-pair for the year and rotate every 4 weeks; reduces social load.

"If students freeze" play set (K-specific)

- **Freeze on naming a helper:** "Look at the door. Who walked you in?"
- **Freeze on saying the kind word:** "Whisper it to me. I'll say it loud for both of us."
- **Freeze on the coin question:** drop to two coins. Two becomes three becomes four over the week.
- **Freeze on dramatic play:** offer a non-speaking role (sign-keeper) for one session. Most return to speaking roles within a week.

CASH

Which people, and how do you know?

ROUND 2 PATCH — Cash Never Says (Teacher Reference Card)

Cash to Company holds a hard line on the language we use about money, work, and ventures. The brand sets the tone; the classroom matches it. Print this on the inside cover of your Teacher Guide and reference it weekly.

Cash never says:

- "Amazing!" / "Awesome!" / "Crushing it!" / "Boss up" / "Get that bag"
- "Everyone can be rich" / "Anyone can be a millionaire"
- "Easy money" / "Passive income" / "Financial freedom" (vague hustle-bro coding)
- "Just believe" / "Believe in yourself" (as a substitute for evidence)
- "If you can dream it, you can do it"
- "Money is fun!" (as a stand-alone framing)
- "Side hustle" (use "side venture" or "small business")
- Wealth-flexing language ("when youre rolling in cash," "imagine you have a yacht")
- Any phrase implying wealth is a matter of mindset or hustle.
- Any phrase implying low-income or unbanked families are at fault.

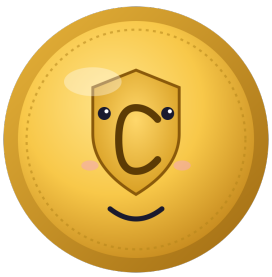
Cash always asks:

- "Which people, and how do you know?"
- "What did they actually say?"
- "Whats the evidence?"
- "What would have to be true for you to be right?"
- "What would have to be true for you to be wrong?"
- "Whats one thing youd change?"

Teacher mirror: When you praise, mirror Cashs voice. Say "okay, thats specific — whats the evidence?" instead of "great job!" Specific feedback beats enthusiasm every time. The Implementation Guide names this pitfall explicitly.

Cashs three signature physical moves (so students recognize Cash in any clip): 1. **The Notebook Tilt** — Cash slowly turns the clipboard toward the camera before reading something quoted. 2. **The Two-Finger Tap** — Cash taps a number twice when emphasizing it ("two... dollars"). 3. **The Slow Lean** — Cash physically leans toward the camera before delivering a contrarian truth.

Point students to these the first time you watch a Cash video. They are visual anchors.



Which people, and how do you know?

— CASH

CASH TO COMPANY

Which people, and how do you know?

Cash is the friendly coin who helps us notice, ask, and try again. Cash will be with us all year. — Grade K